

Drip Irrigation and Water Management for Small Farms

Getting water to the root zone efficiently and fairly

Why Drip

Drip irrigation delivers water slowly and directly to the root zone, cutting waste, keeping foliage dry (which reduces disease), and stretching limited water further — an advantage that matters most in dry spells and where water access is contested.

Components of a Simple System

- A water source and a backflow preventer to protect it.
- A pressure regulator and filter to keep emitters from clogging.
- Mainline tubing to the beds, with drip tape or emitter line down each row.
- A timer for consistent scheduling — consistency prevents cracking and blossom-end rot.

Scheduling

- Most vegetables need roughly 1–1.5 inches of water per week, including rain.
- Water deeply and less often to grow deep, drought-resilient roots.
- Early morning is the best time to irrigate.
- Check soil moisture by feel a few inches down rather than watering on a fixed habit.

A Note on Water Rights

For small and historically underserved farms, secure and fair water access can be as important as any tool. Growers facing disputes over wells, withdrawals, or shared sources should document their use and seek help early from extension, legal aid, or farmer-advocacy organizations.